

Settling in

Most larvae get eaten by fish and other animals, but a few survive and settle on the rocky bottom. Here, they transform into little flowerlike creatures, called polyps, that have sprouting tentacles.



Making a community

A thin layer of skin grows out around the bottom of each polyp and sprouts more polyps to form a colony. Underneath the skin, the coral grows a skeleton of a hard chalky substance, which thickens to form a reef.

Coral polyps catch tiny animals with their stinging tentacles. Many polyps contain algae that produce food by using the energy of sunlight—just like plants do.

Life on the coral

Coral reefs provide food and shelter for thousands of animals, including crabs, anemones, and fish. Some corals, such as staghorn coral, grow upward branches, while others turn into huge rocky mounds.

Fishy friends Sea anemones use their stinging tentacles to protect clown fish from bigger fish. The clown fish are covered in thick slime so they don't get stung. In return, the clown fish gives sea anemones scraps of leftover food.



Emperor angelfish Some fish change appearance as they grow. A young emperor angelfish has a completely different pattern than an adult, so they look like different types of fish.



Coral farming Sadly, many reefs have been damaged by pollution and too much fishing. Some scientists are helping restore them by growing corals in underwater nurseries.

